SURFDESK

Surfdesk vs Clarity Human Services

Updated November 12, 2026. Clarity details come from Bitfocus's public website, help center and software directories. Check with Bitfocus for current specifics.

The short version

They do different jobs, and many agencies will use both.

- **Clarity Human Services** (by Bitfocus) is a **Homeless Management Information System (HMIS)**: the official, HUD-compliant database a Continuum of Care (CoC) uses to report to federal funders and run coordinated entry across agencies.
- **Surfdesk** is the **day-to-day workspace for staff**: fast notes, follow-ups, reminders, check-ins and team visibility, at a published price you can start today.

If your funding requires HMIS reporting, Clarity (or another approved HMIS) stays your **system of record**. Surfdesk is where your team actually keeps up with clients between HMIS entries, and where small programs without an HMIS requirement can run everything.

What each is built for

	Surfdesk	Clarity Human Services
Main purpose	Daily caseload and follow-up workspace	HMIS: federal data collection and reporting
Built for	Individuals, small teams, nonprofits and agencies of any size	CoCs, HMIS lead agencies and HUD-funded providers
Who chooses it	Each person or agency signs up on its own	Usually picked by the CoC or HMIS lead for the whole community
Getting started	Sign up online in minutes; import a client list from Excel	Set up under a contract with Bitfocus, usually through the CoC
Pricing	Published: $9/month individual; $19/seat team	Custom quote per contract (not published)

Capabilities side by side

✅ = yes · ◖ = partly · — = no · ? = not confirmed publicly

Capability	Surfdesk	Clarity
Federal compliance		

Capability	Surfdesk	Clarity
HUD reports (APR, CAPER, LSA, SPM, PIT)	—	✅
SAMHSA, RHY and VA reports	—	✅
HUD HMIS CSV export	—	✅
HUD data elements and standard intake screens	—	✅
Coordinated entry		
Coordinated entry assessments and prioritization	—	✅
Real-time housing/resource reservation	—	✅
Referrals between agencies	◖ public referral link into your agency	✅
Daily work		
Plain-English command bar ("remind me to call Ana Friday")	✅	—
Voice entry on any field	✅	?
Notes that suggest follow-up tasks automatically	✅	?
Personal tasks with repeats, snooze and reminders	✅	◖ case-related
Personal notes and lists kept private from the agency	✅	?
Calendar with Google, Apple and Outlook sync	✅	?
Quick check-in / meeting logging	✅	✅ services and encounters
Front-desk self check-in kiosk	✅	?
Referral form with appointment booking and duplicate check	✅	◖ CE referrals
Install on any phone as an app	✅	◖ mobile field use
Team and reporting		
Roles (member, manager, admin)	✅	✅
Manager view of every client	✅	✅
Activity log	✅	?
Funder-ready impact report (people served, demographics, busiest times) as PDF/Excel	✅	✅ via report library

Capability	Surfdesk	Clarity
Custom dashboards and business intelligence	◖ fixed Impact dashboard	✅
Data sharing across many agencies in a community	—	✅
Data and access		
Import client list from Excel/CSV	✅	?
Export everything any time	✅	✅
Two-step sign-in, auto sign-out	✅	?
Self-serve sign-up and cancel online	✅	— contract

Where Clarity is the right tool

- You receive **HUD CoC or ESG funding** and must report through an HMIS.
- Your community runs **coordinated entry** and needs shared assessments, prioritization lists and housing reservations.
- Many agencies in your area need to **share client data** in one system.

Bitfocus says Clarity ships with the HUD data elements, entry screens and standard reports for HMIS compliance, a library of more than 175 prebuilt reports, and coordinated entry built into the workflow.

Where Surfdesk is the right tool

- **Speed for staff.** Logging a note or follow-up is one sentence, not a multi-screen form, so more actually gets written down.
- **Nothing slips.** Reminders, suggested tasks from notes, "needs attention" and stale-client flags keep follow-ups on time.
- **Small programs and teams** with no HMIS requirement get case management, check-ins, referrals and funder reports without a procurement process.
- **Front-door tools:** a self check-in kiosk and a public referral link with appointment booking.
- **Staff keep a personal workspace.** Their own tasks, notes and lists stay private, while client records stay with the agency.
- **Transparent cost:** published prices, monthly billing, cancel any time, and a 14-day free trial for teams.

Using them together

1. Staff use **Surfdesk** all day: check-ins, notes, follow-ups, reminders and the kiosk.
2. Required HUD data elements and services are entered in **Clarity** as your CoC requires.
3. Managers use Surfdesk's **Team** view and **Impact** reports for day-to-day management and quick funder updates. Clarity remains the source for official HUD reports.

Surfdesk doesn't sync with Clarity yet. An HMIS-ready export is on our list of possible organization features.

Sources for Clarity details: Bitfocus · Regulatory compliance · Coordinated entry · Report library · HUD CSV export · AWS Marketplace listing · Capterra